

AN ESSAY ON FAITH AND ATTENTION

The Digital Detox

On Silence, Sovereignty, and the Soul

“Attachment to this world is the root of all grief.”

— Ibn al-Qayyim al-Jawziyyah, Al-Fawā'id

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I. The Architecture of Distraction

There is a kind of poverty that looks like abundance.

A man with a thousand channels and nothing to watch. A woman with five hundred friends and no one who truly knows her. A generation with access to every idea humanity has ever produced — and an attention span too shattered to hold a single one of them for longer than eight seconds.

We are the most connected people who have ever lived. And we are among the loneliest.

Something has been stolen from us. Not by force — but by design, by habit, by the slow and almost imperceptible erosion of the one thing no algorithm can replace: the capacity to be still.

There is a scene in Dostoevsky's *The Idiot* where Prince Myshkin describes the moment before an epileptic seizure — a flash of clarity so total, so luminous, that he calls it “the highest mode of existence.”¹ A moment where the noise of life falls completely away, and what remains is pure, undivided presence.

I used to think that kind of clarity required a condition. A gift. Something given to a few and withheld from the rest. I no longer believe that. I believe it is available to anyone willing to pay its price. And its price is simple, if not easy: you must turn the phone off.

The neuroscientist Dr. Gloria Mark of UC Irvine found that after a single digital interruption, it takes an average of twenty-three minutes to return to a state of deep focus.² Twenty-three minutes — gone, not to productivity, not to rest, but to the cognitive static of re-orientation. We experience dozens of these interruptions every waking hour. Most of us have not had a complete, uninterrupted thought in years.

“The heart is like a mirror. When it faces the world constantly, it becomes covered in rust — and a rusted mirror cannot reflect the light of God.”³

— Imam Al-Ghazali, *Iḥyā' Ulūm al-Dīn*

He was speaking of *ghaflah* — heedlessness. The state of being so absorbed in the surface of things that the depth disappears. Al-Ghazali spent years mapping the interior of the human soul, and what he found at the center of nearly every spiritual illness was the same root: a heart too crowded with the world to make room for anything greater. We have simply built machines that crowd the heart faster than anything he could have imagined.

II. The Scroll and the Shattered Self

Consider what happens in a single minute of scrolling.

A football team's highlight reel — their finest moments, joy compressed to sixty seconds. Then, before the feeling has settled: a child from Gaza. From Sudan. From Lebanon. From Congo. Eyes wide. Voice cracking. Then — without transition, without mercy — a comedy clip.

Your dopamine does not know where to land. A minute of ecstasy. A minute of grief. A minute of hollow laughter. The cycle repeats, endlessly, until you are no longer a person feeling things — you are a receiver, passively absorbing frequencies that were never meant to coexist.

“Excessive positivity produces an inability to ‘let things be.’ The hyperactive, hyper-attentive ego cannot experience deep boredom — and it is in deep boredom that the genuinely new can emerge.”⁴

— Byung-Chul Han, *The Burnout Society*

Ibn al-Qayyim understood this intimately. He wrote in *Madārij al-Sālikīn* — his masterwork on the stations of the spiritual journey — that the heart can only hold so much. Every image the eye consumes, every piece of news the mind processes, occupies space. And space occupied by the world is space unavailable for God.⁵

“The servant’s heart will never find peace until it abandons what was not created for it, and returns to what it was created for.”⁶

— Ibn al-Qayyim, *Madārij al-Sālikīn*

III. The Experiment: A Harder Kind of Hard

To break the cycle, I needed more than a habit change. I needed a rupture — a deliberate, structured hijra of the self. A migration away from noise and toward meaning.

What began as a framework inspired by the 75 Hard Challenge was transformed into something spiritually weightier. Not discipline for the sake of discipline. But tawbah. Turning. The kind of turning the Qur'an speaks of when it says:⁷

“And turn to Allah in repentance, all of you, O believers, that you might succeed.”⁷

— Sūrah Al-Nūr, 24:31

Deep Qur'anic Study

Not recitation as routine — lips moving while the mind wanders. But engagement as conversation. Moving through the text slowly, with a mufassir's commentary alongside. Ibn Kathir wrote that the Qur'an was revealed to be acted upon — that knowledge of it without transformation is a proof against its reader, not for him.⁸ This landed differently at 4 AM than it ever had at 9 PM.

Ghadd al-Basar — The Lowering of the Gaze

In its traditional legal sense, yes. But broader. A lowering of the gaze from spectacle. From the endless parade of tragedy-as-content, luxury-as-aspiration, outrage-as-entertainment. Ibn al-Qayyim devoted an entire chapter of *Al-Jawāb al-Kāfi* to the damage done by the unguarded eye, calling it “the messenger of desire” and “the arrow of Iblīs.”⁹

“Whoever guards his gaze, Allah illuminates his heart with light and insight.”⁹

— Ibn al-Qayyim, *Al-Jawāb al-Kāfi*

Arriving Before the Prayer

Not sprinting through the mosque door as the iqama is called — breathless, phone still warm in the pocket, mind still half-elsewhere. But arriving a full minute early. Sitting. Letting the world fall away. The Prophet, peace be upon him, said: “When any one of you stands for prayer, he is conversing with his Lord.”¹⁰ A conversation requires presence. I had been arriving late to the most important conversation of my day.

IV. Ten Days — A Chronicle of the Interior

“Whoever knows himself knows his Lord.”¹¹

— Attributed to the Sufi tradition, echoed by Ibn 'Arabī and Al-Ghazali

Ten days is not long. The scholars teach that spiritual transformation is measured in years — that the heart, long rusted, softens slowly, the way dawn comes not in a flash but in a gradual brightening that you notice only after it has already changed everything. But even ten days can shift the angle of the light.

On Prayer

Maghrib, Isha, and Fajr became the architecture of time itself. Not interruptions in a busy day — but the pillars around which everything else arranged itself. I began to

understand what the early Muslims meant when they described prayer not as something they did, but as something they returned to. Every prayer is a homecoming.

Dostoevsky wrote in a letter from Siberia: “If anyone proved to me that Christ was outside the truth, I would prefer to stay with Christ rather than with the truth.”¹² He was speaking of a different tradition. But he was speaking of the same longing — the longing for a center that does not move, a north star that holds when everything else shifts.

On Qur'an

The tilawa stopped being historical. The Imam's voice carried words that landed not in my mind but in my chest. Warm. Hoping. Speaking directly to us, from Allah.

“I came to feel that I was reading a new Qur'an — not because it had changed, but because I had changed. When the heart is prepared, the words of Allah do not merely enter the mind. They enter the life.”¹³

— Sayyid Qutb, *Fī Zilāl al-Qur'an* (In the Shade of the Qur'an)

On Sleep & Fajr

9:30 PM became late. Peaceful late. 4:00 AM became the climax of the night — not a sacrifice, but a gift. There is a quality of silence at that hour that cannot be manufactured. The Prophet, peace be upon him, said: “Our Lord descends every night to the lowest heaven when the last third of the night remains, and says: Who is calling upon Me, that I may answer him?”¹⁴ To be awake in that hour is to be present for an invitation most people sleep through.

On Sound

Music lost its meaning — not through force, not through guilt. Simply because when the hours are filled with Al-Dossari and Al-Nufais — with voices that carry the Qur'an the way a river carries light — other sounds begin to seem thin. Decorative. Empty.

“Islam did not come to destroy beauty. It came to liberate it from decoration and return it to meaning.”¹⁵

— Alija Izetbegović, *Islam Between East and West*

On Reading

Boredom used to have a reflex. The moment a quiet second appeared — waiting for the bus, sitting between tasks, the pause before sleep — the thumb moved on its

own. Not because there was something to find. Just because stillness felt unbearable.

Now that same silence holds a book.

These ten days: *Crime and Punishment* by Dostoevsky. *Islam Between East and West* by Alija Izetbegović.

Two books. Both heavy. Both asking questions the scroll never thought to ask.

“Man is the only being in nature who is dissatisfied with himself. This dissatisfaction is not a defect — it is his greatest dignity. It is the sign that he was made for something more.”¹⁶

— Alija Izetbegović, *Islam Between East and West*

Ten days of reading this felt like being slowly remembered.

V. What the Silence Gives Back

“Be in this world as though you are a stranger or a wayfarer.”¹⁷

— The Prophet Muhammad, peace be upon him, narrated by Ibn ‘Umar

What this experiment has returned to me is not peace as the absence of difficulty. Gaza is still Gaza. The world has not resolved itself because I looked away from the feed. The problems are real. The grief is legitimate. The obligation to care — and to act — remains.

What has changed is something more fundamental: the relationship between the inner and the outer.

Al-Ghazali describes the soul as a kingdom perpetually at war. The lower self — the *nafs ammāra* — pulls constantly toward noise, novelty, the endless consumption of sensation. The higher self — the *qalb*, the heart at its best — longs for stillness, for meaning, for the One who made it. Every choice is a vote for one side or the other.

Ten days of voting for the heart.

“The more the servant turns toward Allah, the more Allah turns toward him. And the more he turns away, the more distant he becomes — not because Allah has moved, but because he has.”¹⁸

— Ibn al-Qayyim, *Al-Fawā'id*

I had moved. Far, and gradually, and without noticing — drawn by each notification, each reel, each algorithmically perfect hit of outrage or desire, one small step at a time, away from the center.

These ten days are the beginning of the walk back.

The feed will always be there. It will always have something louder, faster, more outrageous than whatever came before. It is designed — by the most brilliant engineers alive, armed with more data about your psychology than you have yourself — to hold your attention until there is nothing left of it to hold.

But there is another design. Older. Wiser. Made not by engineers but by revelation, refined not through A/B testing but through fourteen centuries of human souls finding their way home.

Pray before the world asks anything of you.

Read what challenges you, not what entertains you.

Lower your gaze from the spectacle.

Arrive early. Be still.

Let the Qur'an speak — and this time, actually listen.

"And in the remembrance of Allah do hearts find rest."¹⁹

— Sūrah Al-Ra'd, 13:28

The noise was always optional.

The silence was always there.

I had simply — for a long time — stopped choosing it.

Notes

1. Fyodor Dostoevsky, *The Idiot*, on Prince Myshkin's description of the moment preceding an epileptic seizure.
2. Gloria Mark, University of California, Irvine — research on attention recovery time following digital interruption.
3. Abū Ḥāmid al-Ghazālī, *Iḥyā' 'Ulūm al-Dīn* ("The Revival of the Religious Sciences").
4. Byung-Chul Han, *The Burnout Society* (Stanford University Press, 2015).
5. Ibn al-Qayyim al-Jawziyyah, *Madārij al-Sālikīn* ("Stations of the Seekers").
6. *Madārij al-Sālikīn*, on the heart's finite capacity and its need to return to its original purpose.
7. Qur'an 24:31 (*Sūrat al-Nūr*).
8. Ibn Kathīr, *Tafsīr Ibn Kathīr* — on the Qur'an as revelation meant to be enacted, not merely recited.
9. Ibn al-Qayyim al-Jawziyyah, *al-Jawāb al-Kāfi liman Sa'ala 'an al-Dawā' al-Shāfi*, on the unguarded gaze.
10. Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī, on prayer as direct conversation with one's Lord.
11. Attributed to the broader Sufi tradition; the sentiment is echoed across the writings of Ibn 'Arabī and al-Ghazālī.
12. Fyodor Dostoevsky, letter to Natalya Fonvizina, 1854, written during his Siberian exile.
13. Sayyid Qutb, *Fī Zīlāl al-Qur'an* ("In the Shade of the Qur'an").
14. Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī and Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim, on Allah's descent to the lowest heaven in the last third of the night.
15. Alija Izetbegović, *Islam Between East and West*, on beauty and meaning in Islam.
16. Alija Izetbegović, *Islam Between East and West*, on dissatisfaction as a mark of human dignity.
17. Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī, narrated by Ibn 'Umar, on regarding this world as a temporary sojourn.
18. Ibn al-Qayyim al-Jawziyyah, *al-Fawā'id* ("The Beneficial Notes").
19. Qur'an 13:28 (*Sūrat al-Ra'd*).

About the Author

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